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ARTICLE

The Strongest El Niño In 75 Years Could Trigger A Global Food Crisis





BY PNW STAFF JULY 11, 2026

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For most people, El Niño sounds like just another weather event. Meteorologists talk about warmer ocean temperatures, shifting wind patterns, and changing rainfall, while the rest of us assume it is simply another season of unusual weather.

But this time is different.

The latest forecasts from NOAA's Climate Prediction Center suggest the current El Niño could become one of the strongest recorded in the last 75 years. While no single weather event guarantees disaster, history shows that powerful El Niño cycles have repeatedly triggered droughts, floods, crop failures, livestock losses, and soaring food prices across multiple continents at the same time.

That should concern every family--not because panic is warranted, but because our modern food system is far more fragile than most people realize.

For decades we've been told globalization made everything more efficient. It certainly did. The problem is that efficiency often came at the expense of resilience.

Today, many of the world's most important food supplies are concentrated in surprisingly few locations.

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Three countries dominate the export market for many staple crops including corn, soybeans, rice, sugar, and palm oil. That works wonderfully during good years. But when one of those regions experiences drought, flooding, or severe storms, the entire world feels the consequences.

It's the agricultural version of putting all your eggs in one basket.

Now imagine several baskets getting hit simultaneously.

That is exactly why economists are paying such close attention to this developing El Niño.

Goldman Sachs analysts recently warned that modern agricultural markets have become increasingly vulnerable because weather disruptions no longer remain local problems. Governments often react by restricting exports to protect their own populations, importers begin stockpiling supplies, and suddenly a modest production shortfall snowballs into a global price shock.

We watched this happen during the COVID pandemic.

We watched it after Russia invaded Ukraine.

And we could see it again if weather conditions deteriorate over the coming year.

The concern isn't simply whether rice production falls in one country or sugar harvests disappoint somewhere else. The real danger lies in how governments respond.

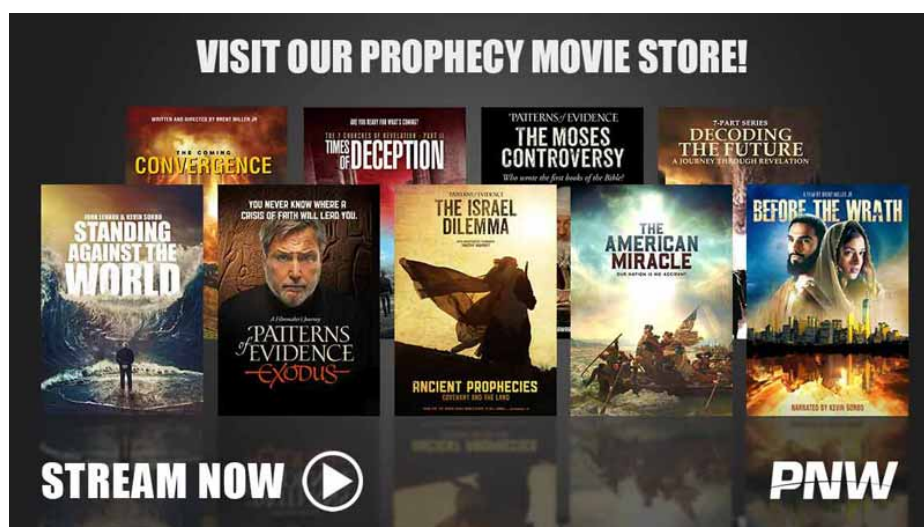
Once nations begin limiting exports, global supply shrinks even further.

Panic buying begins.

Prices spike.

Poorer nations struggle to compete for available food.

History shows this chain reaction often creates far more damage than the original harvest loss itself.



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This developing El Niño arrives at perhaps the worst possible time.

Global fertilizer markets remain vulnerable to geopolitical instability. Shipping lanes through the Middle East continue to face uncertainty. Energy prices influence fertilizer production, transportation costs, and irrigation expenses. Many countries are also expanding biofuel mandates that divert crops like corn, sugar, and vegetable oils away from food production and toward fuel.

Every one of these factors individually raises costs.

Together they create the perfect environment for food inflation.

Many Americans assume our grocery stores insulate us from these global problems.

That assumption deserves reconsideration.

The average supermarket carries only a limited inventory. Modern supply chains operate on "just-in-time" logistics designed to minimize storage costs rather than maximize emergency reserves. If multiple disruptions occur simultaneously, shortages can develop surprisingly quickly.

We've already seen glimpses of this over the past several years.

Egg shortages.

Olive oil shortages.

Coffee price spikes.

Chocolate becoming more expensive.



Produce shortages after regional weather disasters.

None of these occurred because the world ran out of food.

They occurred because localized disruptions rippled through highly interconnected supply chains.

Now multiply that across dozens of agricultural commodities at once.

The consequences could extend far beyond higher grocery bills.

Food insecurity has historically been one of the world's greatest drivers of political instability.

The Arab Spring was fueled in part by soaring bread prices.

Numerous governments throughout history have fallen after prolonged food shortages.

Migration often accelerates when farming regions become unproductive.

Civil unrest increases when basic necessities become unaffordable.

Food has always been about much more than food.

It is about national security.

It is about economic stability.

It is about social order.

One overlooked concern involves human psychology.

Markets often react before harvests fail.

If traders anticipate poor crops, prices begin climbing months in advance. Governments seeing higher prices may impose export restrictions before shortages even materialize. Consumers respond by buying more than usual. Retailers order larger inventories.

Fear itself becomes part of the supply problem.

This feedback loop can turn uncertainty into reality.

Does that mean catastrophe is inevitable?

No.

NOAA itself cautions that even the strongest El Niño events do not produce identical outcomes everywhere. Some regions benefit from increased rainfall while others suffer drought. Weather remains notoriously difficult to predict with precision.

That uncertainty cuts both ways.

Forecasts could improve.

Or they could worsen.

What deserves attention isn't merely this year's weather outlook.

It is what this developing situation reveals about the extraordinary fragility of the global systems we have built.



Our grandparents lived in communities that often produced much of their own food locally.

Today, a meal on your dinner table may depend upon fertilizer produced on another continent, shipped through contested waterways, applied to crops thousands of miles away, harvested by imported labor, processed elsewhere, transported across oceans, and delivered through logistics networks operating with minimal margin for error.

It's an astonishing achievement.

It's also remarkably vulnerable.

Scripture repeatedly reminds us that mankind ultimately does not control creation. Weather, harvests, and the rhythms of the earth remain under God's sovereign authority. Throughout biblical history, droughts and famines often exposed humanity's dependence upon Him rather than our own ingenuity.

Whether this El Niño ultimately becomes historic or merely another challenging weather cycle remains to be seen.

But one lesson is already clear.

Our food system is far less secure than many imagine.

The next major global crisis may not begin with a financial collapse or military conflict.

It may begin quietly--in fields drying under relentless heat, in flooded rice paddies thousands of miles away, and eventually, in the price tag on the groceries sitting in your shopping cart.

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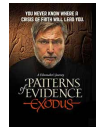
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